

GALLERY DUTCH ART

The 18-Month Window

AI, the future of humanity, and how to prepare

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AI, the future of humanity, and how to prepare before everyone else does

A short, shareable booklet. Read it in 20 minutes. Act on it for the rest of your life.

Foreword: This is not hype, and it's not doom

Most writing about AI is either "robots will save us" or "robots will kill us." Both are lazy. The truth is more useful and more urgent: **AI is the fastest redistribution of capability in human history**, and a small number of people are quietly reorganising their lives around it while everyone else waits to be told it's safe.

This booklet is for the people who'd rather move early. It won't make you an engineer. It will change how you spend your next eighteen months.

~~The~~ **one idea**: Intelligence is becoming cheap and abundant. When something becomes abundant, value moves to whatever stays scarce. Your job is to figure out what stays scarce — and become that.

Chapter 1: What's actually happening

Three things are true at once:

1. **AI can now do real work** — not just chat, but research, code, design, plan and *act* through tools and agents.
2. **It's getting better fast** — capabilities that were research demos last year are products this year.
3. **Almost nobody has adjusted** — most workplaces, schools and individuals still operate as if this isn't happening.

That gap — between what's possible and what people are doing — is the opportunity. Gaps like this don't stay open. They close, usually within a couple of years, and they close *suddenly*.

Chapter 2: What becomes worthless, and what becomes priceless

When intelligence is abundant, the following **lose** relative value: rote knowledge, "I know how to use this software," routine analysis, first drafts, and being the person who simply executes instructions.

The following **gain** value, fast:

- **Judgement** — knowing which question matters and which answer is wrong.
- **Taste** — the human sense of what is good, beautiful, appropriate.
- **Trust & relationships** — people still buy from, and follow, people.
- **Agency** — the willingness to start, decide and own outcomes.
- **Synthesis across fields** — connecting things no single agent was pointed at.
- **Ethics & responsibility** — someone has to be accountable; machines can't be.

~~Remember~~ **Remember**: The future doesn't belong to people who *compete* with AI. It belongs to people who *direct* it — and who bring the human things it cannot.

Chapter 3: The four kinds of people in an AI world

1. **The Deniers** — "it's a fad." They'll be the most surprised, and the least prepared.
2. **The Frozen** — they see it, they're anxious, they do nothing. The largest group.
3. **The Consumers** — they use AI casually for trivia and memes. Mildly better off.
4. **The Directors** — they treat AI as a team to manage, building leverage in their work and life.

The whole game is moving yourself into group four. It is almost entirely a matter of decision, not talent.

Chapter 4: The skills to learn now (your real curriculum)

Forget learning to code "because AI." Learn these:

1. **Clear thinking & briefing.** The new superpower is describing exactly what you want. Practise writing precise instructions; the clearer your thinking, the more AI multiplies it.
 2. **Critical judgement.** AI is confidently wrong sometimes. Learn to verify, to smell nonsense, to ask "how would I know if this is false?"
 3. **Delegation & orchestration.** Learn to manage AI like a team: assign, review, correct. This is a *management* skill more than a technical one.
 4. **Taste & creativity.** Develop a strong point of view. When everyone can generate, the rare thing is knowing what's *worth* generating.
 5. **Emotional & relational skills.** Empathy, persuasion, leadership, care — the irreducibly human work, now more valuable, not less.
 6. **Learning to learn.** The half-life of specific tools is short. The meta-skill of re-learning every six months is permanent.
 7. **Ethics & responsibility.** As AI acts, humans must own the consequences. Being the trustworthy, accountable person becomes a career advantage.
 8. **Health & attention.** In a world engineered for distraction and outsourced thinking, the ability to focus, rest and stay sane is a competitive edge.
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Chapter 5: Your 90-day preparation plan

Days 1–30 — Get fluent.

Use AI daily for real work. Pick three recurring tasks and do them with AI. Keep a note of what worked and what failed. Goal: lose the fear, build the habit.

Days 31–60 — Get leverage.

Move from chatting to *delegating*. Try an agent or automation for one boring workflow. Learn to write proper briefs. Goal: get back 3–5 hours a week.

Days 61–90 — Get positioned.

Ask: in my field, what will be scarce when AI is everywhere? Aim yourself at that — the judgement, the relationships, the taste. Start building a reputation for it. Goal: a clear, AI-proof angle for the next five years.

The discipline: 30 minutes a day, every day, beats a heroic weekend once. Compounding is the whole strategy.

Chapter 6: The big questions (don't outsource these)

Preparing isn't only practical. As machines take more of the *doing*, humans are pushed back onto the questions that matter:

- What is work *for*, if not survival?
- What do I want to be excellent at, for its own sake?
- What kind of person do I want to be when most tasks are optional?
- What do I owe the people who adapt more slowly than me?

A society that gets the technology right and the wisdom wrong will not be a good place to live. The most important preparation is partly *character*.

Chapter 7: The future of humanity — the honest version

Three futures are genuinely possible:

- **Abundance** — AI lifts the floor for everyone: cheaper healthcare, education, expertise; humans freed for creativity, care and meaning.

- **Concentration** — the gains pool with a few; most people become passive consumers of someone else's intelligence.
- **Chaos** — we move faster than our wisdom and institutions can handle.

Which one we get is not decided by the technology. It's decided by millions of individual choices — including yours, starting this week. Optimism is not a prediction; it's a *responsibility*.

The Manifesto (share this part)

1. Intelligence is becoming abundant. Plan your life around that, not around denial.
 2. Don't compete with AI. Direct it.
 3. Become what stays scarce: judgement, taste, trust, agency, care.
 4. Use it daily. Fluency beats theory.
 5. Delegate, then review. Manage AI like a team.
 6. Keep a human in charge of consequences. Own your outcomes.
 7. Re-learn every six months. The meta-skill is permanent.
 8. Protect your attention and your health. They are now strategic assets.
 9. Move early. The gap between possible and done is the opportunity, and it's closing.
 10. Use your advantage to bring others along. The future should have more people in it.
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If you read this far, you're already not in the "Frozen" group. Now pick one thing from the 90-day plan and start today.

— A booklet meant to be passed on. Send it to one person who needs to read it.

